ARIZONA RULE OF LAW AMBASSADOR PROGRAM

Speaker Script Guide

Prepared for Ted Schmidt

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How to Use This Guide

This guide provides a full speaking script for each slide in the Ambassador Program presentation, organized for ease of reference at the podium or in preparation. Each slide section includes the script itself, an estimated delivery time, a key message summary, and—where applicable—optional interactive elements for more engaged audiences.

Presentation Formats

Format	Duration	Slides	Notes
Condensed	20 minutes	1–3, 6–9, 13–16	Use shortened scripts; skip optional elements
Standard	45 minutes	All slides	Full scripts as written
Interactive	60 minutes	All slides	Add Q&A after Slides 7, 12, and 14; facilitate discussion after Slide 15

General Delivery Principles

- Know your audience — tailor examples to their background, profession, or community.
- Stay nonpartisan — if a question becomes political, redirect to shared constitutional principles.
- Pause intentionally — silence after a key point is more powerful than rushing forward.
- Adapt language freely — this script is a foundation, not a script to be read verbatim.
- Close with conviction — the final charge is a call to action; deliver it with energy.

SLIDE 1 TITLE SLIDE — ARIZONA RULE OF LAW AMBASSADOR PROGRAM

1 – 1.5 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Establish your role as an educator, not a partisan advocate. Set the tone immediately.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Good [morning/afternoon/evening], and thank you for having me.

My name is [Your Name], and I am a [practicing attorney / legal professional] here in Arizona.

I am honored to be part of the Arizona Rule of Law Ambassador Program — a program established by the State Bar of Arizona in partnership with the Arizona Supreme Court to bring conversations about our constitutional foundations directly into communities like this one.

I want to be clear about something from the outset: I am here today not as a partisan advocate, and not to talk about any particular law, case, or political figure. I am here as an educator — to talk about something that belongs to all of us, regardless of party or politics: the Rule of Law.

What I hope you take away today is a clearer understanding of what the Rule of Law actually means, why it is under pressure right now, and what each of us — lawyers and citizens alike — can do to protect it.

SLIDE 2 WHY WE ARE HERE

⏱ *2 – 2.5 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Root the program in a concrete, recent Arizona moment — not an abstraction.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Let me start by explaining why Arizona created this program — and why now.

On February 12, 2026, Arizona established its first official Rule of Law Day. The date was chosen
deliberately: it is Abraham Lincoln's birthday — a president who understood that democracy survives only when laws, not passions, govern. It falls two days before Arizona's own statehood anniversary.

And this year marks the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence, which established that legitimate government rests on law, not on any one person's will.

On that day, lawyers across Arizona — from Flagstaff to Yuma — gathered in courthouses to retake the oath each of us swore when we were first admitted to practice:

'I will support the Constitution and laws of the United States and the State of Arizona.'

That was not a ceremony for its own sake. It was a recommitment — a public statement that this matters.

The Arizona Supreme Court went further, amending Rule 32 — the rule that defines the State Bar's mission — to explicitly include promoting confidence in the Rule of Law as part of that mission.

This Ambassador Program is the next step. We are training lawyers to go directly into communities like yours to have exactly this conversation. Because the Rule of Law does not preserve itself. It requires an informed public — and lawyers willing to engage.

SLIDE 3 WHAT IS THE RULE OF LAW?

⏱ *1.5 – 2 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Give the audience one sentence they will remember long after they leave the room.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So let's start with the most important question: What exactly is the Rule of Law?

At its core, it means this: we are governed by laws — not by the personal preferences, moods, or ambitions of our leaders. And those laws must be fair, clearly defined, and applied equally to everyone.

Here is the phrase I want you to remember:

No one is above the law. No one is beneath its protection.

That is the entire concept in one sentence.

It means the same rules apply whether you are powerful or powerless, wealthy or struggling, beloved or deeply unpopular. Disputes are not settled by force, by who has the most money, or by who shouts the loudest. They are settled by neutral courts applying known, published rules.

The Rule of Law is what separates a constitutional democracy from authoritarianism. It is what turns ideals written on parchment into functioning institutions. And it is what allows a free people to disagree — sometimes fiercely — without descending into chaos.

Optional Addition — For Deeper or Professional Audiences:

"The International Academy of Trial Lawyers defines the Rule of Law as requiring that all persons and institutions — including governments — are subject to law, have access to legal protections regardless of economic means, and can challenge governmental action in a court of law. It requires that laws be clearly defined, accessible, and enforced impartially by an independent judiciary."

SLIDE 4 FOUR CORE PRINCIPLES

⏱ *1.5 – 2 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Give the audience a framework they can carry with them — four principles, clearly named.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

The World Justice Project — an international organization that tracks the Rule of Law in 142 countries — breaks this concept into four core principles. These are the building blocks.

First: Accountability. Government officials and private actors alike are subject to the law. No one receives a pass simply because of rank, wealth, or political affiliation.

Second: Just Law. Laws must be clear, publicly available, stable over time, and protective of fundamental rights. You have to be able to know the rules before you are held to them.

Third: Open Government. Laws should be enacted and enforced transparently. The process matters as much as the outcome — and a government that operates in the shadows is a government that has stopped answering to the people.

Fourth: Accessible and Impartial Justice. Justice must be delivered by competent, independent decision-makers — and it must be accessible to everyone, not just to those who can afford it.

When all four of these principles are functioning together, people can trust that outcomes will be fair — even when they disagree with the result. That trust is the foundation everything else is built on.

Optional — For Interactive Audiences:

"Let me pause here. Can anyone think of a situation — in the news, in your community, or in history — where one of these four principles was tested or challenged?"

[Allow one or two responses, then bridge back to the next slide.]

SLIDE 5 HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS

1.5 – 2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Show that this is not a modern political argument — it is the oldest argument in democratic thought.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

This is not a new idea. The Rule of Law has been argued for, fought over, and defended for millennia.

Around 350 BC, Aristotle wrote: 'It is more proper that law should govern than any one of the citizens.'

Even in ancient Greece, people understood that laws — not individuals — should hold ultimate authority.

In the 1600s, John Locke — whose ideas directly shaped our Founding Fathers — wrote that wherever law ends, tyranny begins. That is not rhetoric. It is a warning drawn from centuries of history.

Thomas Jefferson wrote that the most sacred duty of any government is to do equal and impartial justice to all its citizens. That obligation did not expire with the founding generation.

And Abraham Lincoln, leading the nation through its most existential crisis, argued that respect for law must be treated as a political religion — a shared civic faith that transcends party and faction. He understood that without it, the country would not survive.

These are not decorative quotes. They reflect a hard, recurring truth: lawful governance is fragile, and every generation must actively choose to protect it.

SLIDE 6 WHY IT MATTERS — IN EVERYDAY LIFE

2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Make it concrete and personal — the Rule of Law is not an abstraction, it touches every day of their lives.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Let me make this practical, because the Rule of Law is not an abstraction that lives only in courtrooms and law schools. It shapes your daily life in ways that are easy to take for granted.

It protects your rights. Your freedom of speech, your right to due process, your property rights — all of these exist because law restrains arbitrary power. Without the Rule of Law, rights are just words on paper. The law is what gives them teeth.

It creates stability. When rules are clear and consistently applied, families can plan for the future, businesses can invest with confidence, and communities can develop. You know what the rules are, and you can rely on them.

It enables peaceful resolution of disputes. Whether it is a contract disagreement, a property boundary, or a custody matter — the Rule of Law provides a forum to resolve conflict without violence. That is not automatic. That is a system we built.

And perhaps most importantly right now: it allows deep disagreement without disorder. We can have passionate, even furious disagreements about policy and values — and resolve them lawfully. That is the mechanism that prevents a polarized democracy from tearing itself apart.

SLIDE 7 WHY IT MATTERS NOW

⏱ *2 – 2.5 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Be honest about the pressure the Rule of Law is under — without making it partisan. The data does the work.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

I want to be candid with you: the Rule of Law is under real pressure right now. Not just in other countries — here, in the United States.

Polarization and institutional distrust are at historic levels. People across the political spectrum feel that institutions are failing them. That distrust, when it takes root, erodes respect for legal processes regardless of which side of the aisle it comes from.

Misinformation travels faster than ever. Social media and partisan media frequently misrepresent how courts work, what judges actually do, and how the legal system functions. That confusion is not harmless — it undermines public confidence in the very institutions designed to protect people.

Civil discourse is breaking down. When people do not understand lawful channels for change, they are more likely to become hostile, disengaged, or cynical — and cynicism is the enemy of civic participation.

Here is the data: the World Justice Project has documented six consecutive years of global decline in Rule of Law metrics. The United States now ranks 26th out of 142 countries.

And history teaches us something important: democracies rarely collapse all at once.

They erode gradually — when respect for institutions weakens, when norms go unenforced, when enough people decide the rules do not apply to those in power.

That is why this conversation matters. That is why we cannot be complacent.

SLIDE 8 NO ONE ABOVE — NO ONE BENEATH

1 – 1.5 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Return to the core principle with force — this slide is a reset before the second half of the presentation.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Let me bring us back to the foundation — because everything else builds on this:

No one is above the law. No one is beneath its protection.

Think about what that means in full.

The wealthiest person in your community is subject to the same laws as someone who has nothing. A sitting president can be held accountable by the courts. The most unpopular person you can imagine — someone whose views you find abhorrent — still has access to due process and equal protection under the law.

This is what separates a constitutional system from an authoritarian one. In places where the Rule of Law has collapsed — and we have seen this throughout history, and in the world today — the powerful do what they want, and the powerless have no recourse. Courts become instruments of those in power rather than neutral arbiters of justice.

We cannot take this for granted. It has never been self-sustaining.

SLIDE 9 THE LAWYER'S OATH

2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Explain why lawyers specifically are doing this — ground it in obligation, not politics.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

You may be wondering: why is a lawyer standing here talking to you about this?
Why are lawyers the ambassadors for this program?

The answer is in the oath we take.

Every lawyer admitted to practice in Arizona swears: 'I will support the Constitution and laws of the United States and the State of Arizona.'

That oath is not just to our clients. It is to the Constitution. To the legal system itself. To the institutions that protect every person in this room.

Lawyers are officers of the court. We are, in a very real sense, guardians of institutional integrity. We have both a professional and ethical obligation to defend judicial independence and to promote public understanding of and respect for the legal process.

And frankly — our profession depends on the Rule of Law. If people lose faith in courts, in contracts, in legal remedies, our ability to serve our clients disappears entirely. So we have a moral obligation and a practical stake in ensuring the public understands this system.

That is why I am here. And that is why hundreds of Arizona lawyers have volunteered to serve as ambassadors — to have exactly this kind of conversation.

SLIDE 10 RULE OF LAW IN ARIZONA

⏱ *1.5 – 2 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Show the audience that Arizona is acting — this is not theoretical, it is already in motion.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Let me tell you what Arizona has specifically done to institutionalize this commitment.

February 12 is now officially Arizona Rule of Law Day. The symbolism matters — Lincoln's birthday, our statehood anniversary, the Declaration of Independence. These dates connect us to our constitutional heritage and remind us what we inherited and what we are responsible for preserving.

The Arizona Supreme Court amended Rule 32 — the rule that defines the State Bar's mission — to explicitly state that the Bar exists not only to serve the public and promote access to justice, but also to promote confidence in the Rule of Law. That is now part of our official mandate.

On Rule of Law Day, lawyers across the state gathered publicly to retake their oath. That act had meaning precisely because it was visible — a profession recommitting itself in public.

And this Ambassador Program is the direct extension of that commitment. You are part of it right now, simply by being here and engaging with these ideas.

SLIDE 11 HOW TO TALK ABOUT THE RULE OF LAW

1.5 – 2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Equip ambassadors with a communication posture, not just content — how you say it matters as much as what you say.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

One of the things this program trains ambassadors to do is communicate about the Rule of Law in a way that brings people together — not drives them apart.

A few principles that should guide every conversation you have on this topic:

Lead as an educator, not an advocate. This is a constitutional issue, not a partisan one. People across the political spectrum depend on the Rule of Law. Frame it that way, always.

Establish ground rules early. When the topic is something as fundamental as constitutional governance, start by inviting listeners to engage with genuine curiosity — to listen in order to understand, not to rebut. The goal is not to win an argument. It is to deepen understanding.

Find the shared values first. Most people — regardless of political affiliation — believe in fairness, accountability, and equal treatment under the law. Start there.
That common ground is more durable than you think.

SLIDE 12 HANDLING DISAGREEMENT AND MISINFORMATION

2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Give ambassadors practical tools — not theory — for staying productive when a conversation goes sideways.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

You will encounter disagreement. You will hear misinformation. You may hear things that are factually wrong and that frustrate you. Here is how to handle it without losing the room.

Ask where the information came from. Not confrontationally — with genuine curiosity. 'Where did you hear that?' opens a door. It lets you understand the source of the concern and creates space to examine how different outlets frame the same facts differently.

Identify the underlying concern. People often repeat misinformation because it speaks to a real fear. Ask what concerns them most about what they've heard. If you can address the fear rather than just correct the fact, you're having a more productive conversation.

Stay calm. You are the lawyer in the room. People will look to you to model the kind of reasoned, civil discourse you are asking of them. If you become combative, the conversation ends — and you've undermined everything you came to say.

Remember your goal. You are not there to change anyone's mind in a single presentation. You are planting seeds. You are modeling something. That is enough.

Optional Interactive Element:
"Has anyone here ever had a conversation about law or politics that went off the rails? What happened?"
[Allow one or two brief responses, then connect back to the techniques above.]

SLIDE 13 WHAT CITIZENS CAN DO

1.5 – 2 minutes

KEY MESSAGE *Every person in the room has a role — not just lawyers. Give them something concrete to do.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So what can you do — as a citizen — to protect and strengthen the Rule of Law? Let me give you practical, tangible actions that require no law degree.

Engage in civic dialogue. Model exactly what we are doing right now — talking across differences, listening to understand, staying grounded in shared principles.

Vote and serve on juries. These are your two most direct forms of participation in the legal system. Jury service in particular is a powerful act of citizenship. When you sit on a jury, you are literally the system doing its work.

Respect lawful outcomes — even when you disagree with them. This is the hardest one. When a court rules against something you care deeply about, it is natural to be frustrated. But accepting the process — even when you reject the outcome — is what preserves legitimacy for the next dispute, and the one after that.

Champion civic education. Civics knowledge has declined significantly over the past generation. If you have children or grandchildren in school, advocate for rigorous civics education. The next generation needs this more than ours did.

SLIDE 14 WHAT LAWYERS CAN DO

⏱ *1.5 – 2 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *Connect the oath to specific, available actions — make it easy for lawyers in the audience to say yes.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

For any lawyers or legal professionals in the room — here is what you can do.

Volunteer with Arizona Bar Foundation programs. The Foundation runs Mock Trial, We the People, and Constitution Week — programs that bring legal education into Arizona schools. They need judges, speakers, and mentors. Visit azbf.org.

Join State Bar committees and working groups. The Bar has active committees focused on access to justice, judicial independence, and public education. Participation has declined in recent years, and these committees need engaged members.

Present to civic groups, schools, and community organizations. You do not need to be a constitutional scholar. You need to care about these principles and be willing to explain them in plain language. That is what you're trained to do.

Champion the Rule of Law in your daily life — at the dinner table, in your office, in your professional circles. Be someone who stands up for fairness, accountability, and lawful process, especially when it is inconvenient to do so.

Each of us took an oath. This is one way we honor it.

SLIDE 15 CLOSING CHARGE

⏱ *1.5 – 2 minutes*

KEY MESSAGE *End with conviction. Leave them with a challenge they can act on before they go to sleep tonight.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

I want to close with the thought that animates everything we have discussed today:

The Rule of Law does not sustain itself.
It lives only if we teach it, defend it, practice it, and demand it.

It does not exist only in the Constitution, or in statutes, or in courtrooms.
It exists in how we treat each other. In how we resolve our disagreements.
In how we hold our institutions accountable — and in how we educate the people who will inherit those institutions.

This is a shared responsibility. Lawyers have a particular role because of our training and our oath. But every citizen has a stake in this. Every person in this room benefits from the Rule of Law every single day — most of the time without noticing.

So I will leave you with a challenge: What is one thing you will do this week to strengthen the Rule of Law in your community?

Maybe it is having a real conversation with someone you disagree with — and genuinely listening. Maybe it is showing up for jury duty without resentment. Maybe it is asking your local school what it teaches about civics and the Constitution.

Maybe it is simply thinking more carefully about where you get your information and what you do with it.

Whatever it is — do something.

Because the Rule of Law is exactly as strong as we choose to make it.

SLIDE 16 RESOURCES & NEXT STEPS

1 minute

KEY MESSAGE *Leave the audience with credible, accessible resources they can actually use.*

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Before I open it up for questions, let me share a few resources.

The Arizona Bar Foundation runs volunteer programs in schools across the state — Mock Trial, We the People, Constitution Week. Visit azbf.org to get involved.

The O'Connor Institute for American Democracy — named after Justice Sandra Day O'Connor — runs programs on civic education and civil discourse. Find them at oconnorinstitute.org.

The State Bar of Arizona has committees focused on access to justice, judicial independence, and public education. Lawyers can find opportunities at azbar.org.

And the World Justice Project tracks Rule of Law data in 142 countries and offers research you can share.

Visit worldjusticeproject.org.

I will be available after this presentation, and I am happy to take questions now.